

CYCLING



CYCLE SPORTS are held on tracks, roads, and cross-country circuits. Races range from 1,000-m (1,094-yd) sprints on an indoor track to multi-stage events over hundreds of kilometres that last a week or more. Special courses are prepared for off-road racing, which includes cyclocross and mountain-bike racing. Racers ride specialized bikes for the different races. Some need to be as light as possible; others need to be strong, and the top riders have bicycles made for them to their own specifications.



Saddle is set high for more pedalling power.

Criterium bicycle

Road racing

Races take place on courses set along ordinary roads. There are single-stage races and multi-stage events such as the Tour de France, in which the total time determines placings. In individual and team time-trials on the road, the riders start at intervals. Criterium races are 40–100 km (25–62 miles) long. They take place over short courses with many laps, along city streets and through parks.



Tour de France

The world's leading road race is the Tour de France which lasts about three weeks. The overall leader on total time wears the famous yellow jersey for the next stage.

Miguel Indurain

Spanish road racer Miguel Indurain (b. 1964) became the first cyclist to win the Tour de France in five successive years (1991–95), equalling the record number of wins. In 1996, he took first place in the Olympic road time trial.



Track racing

Track races take place on wooden indoor tracks, with banked sides, or flat asphalt outdoor tracks. Races include sprints, in which riders jockey for position before making a last-lap dash, and pursuits, in which riders start on opposite sides of the track, the race won by the fastest rider or when one catches the other.



Riders crouch over the handlebars in a streamlined position.

Disc wheels are more efficient indoors because there is no cross-wind.

Track bicycles have no gears or brakes.



Pursuit bicycle

Composite wheel



Spoked wheel

Types of wheel

The design and material of wheels are constantly being improved to suit particular uses. Weight and shape are the important factors. Using spokes saves weight, but increases drag.



Team pursuit

In team pursuit, riders take turns to lead their group of four. The time of the third rider in each team determines the result. One rider usually makes an all-out effort near the finish before trailing off.



British cyclist Chris Boardman on his revolutionary Lotus bike

Time-trials

In time-trials, competitors ride as fast as possible, on their own, over a set distance or for a fixed time. Time-trials are some of the hardest races and require continuous effort.

Off-road racing

Bicycles for off-road races have chunky tyres for the rough terrain. Cyclocross is the original form of cross-country cycling, with world championships since 1950. Mountain biking is now the most popular form, with world championships since 1990 and Olympic recognition in 1996.

For log hopping, the rider must learn to shift her weight.



Weight over the rear wheel

Mountain biking

Mountain bikes are built to survive rough handling. Most have steel-alloy frames, straight handlebars, and flat knobby tyres. Courses for races have many climbs and descents, with routes over fields and gravel pits.



Rider brings her weight over the front wheel.



Cyclocross

In cyclocross, races take place over laps of a cross-country course. Riders often find it quicker to dismount and carry their bikes over obstacles such as fences, gates, and ditches, and may have to run up steep hills or wade through water with them.

Weight is kept over the front wheel until the hop has been completed.



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